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On the heptasyllabic verses of the Rig-Veda
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Source: *Zeitschrift für vergleichende Sprachforschung*, 91. Bd., 2. H. (1977), pp. 246-255
Published by: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht (GmbH & Co. KG)
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On the heptasyllabic verses of the Rig-Veda

0. *Introductory*

Compared with the so-called 'decasyllabic' variants of trimeter verse in the Rig-Veda, pādas of seven syllables are relatively rare. Many of the occurrences of such pādas, however, are found in passages which must be considered, for independent reasons, to belong to the most archaic layers of Rig-Vedic composition. For this reason alone, the heptasyllabic verses of the Rig-Veda merit careful attention; in this study, we examine the major properties and implications of this Rig-Vedic verse-form.

Section 1 develops some fundamental notions concerning the structure of seven-syllable verses. In section 2 we present a brief account of the distribution of such verses in the Rig-Veda.

The important treatments of the reconstruction of Indo-European metrical practice have paid little attention to the heptasyllable[1]). In section 3, then, we discuss some implications of Rig-Vedic heptasyllables for Indo-European metrics and versification.

1. *Structure*

In his discussion of seven-syllable verses, Arnold distinguishes between 'catalectic verses' and 'heptasyllabic verses'[2]). The former are characterized by a strict closing of the chape ⏑ – ⏒ #, showing clear catalexis of the octosyllabic closing ⏑ – ⏑ ⏒ #. Catalectic verses are frequent in one or two hymns, which belong to the archaic period. 'Heptasyllabic verses', on the other hand, are quite rare,

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[1]) A. Meillet, *Les origines indo-européennes des mètres grecs* (Paris, 1923); R. Jakobson, 'Studies in comparative Slavic metrics', *Oxford Slavonic Papers* 3, 1952, 21–66 (= *Sel. Wr.* IV, 414–63); C. Watkins, 'Indo-European metrics and archaic Irish verse', *Celtica* 6, 1963, 194–249; G. Nagy, *Comparative studies in Greek and Indic meter* (Cambridge, Mass., 1974); survey with bibliography in R. Schmitt, *Dichtung und Dichtersprache in indogermanischer Zeit* 307–13 (Wiesbaden, 1967).

[2]) E. V. Arnold, *Vedic metre in its historical development* 161 (Cambridge, 1905).

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and 'in most cases some metrical restoration is required'. In accordance with this distinction, Arnold lists the occurrences of 'catalectic' and 'heptasyllabic' verses separately, based on his view that 'heptasyllabic' verses are structurally deviant.

This view, however, cannot be maintained, since a cogent structural distinction can be drawn between the two types[3]). If we examine the last four syllables of the 28 'heptasyllables' listed by Arnold, we notice the striking fact that 19 of these verses exhibit standard octosyllabic closing structures. The greatest proportion (11) show the statistically preponderant iambic closing ⏑ – ⏑ ⏒ ‖: 1.6.4a (*ád áha svadhắm ánu*), 6.16.2b (*jihvábhir yajā maháḥ*), 6.60.4a (*tắ huve yáyor idám*), 8.25.23a (*tắ me áśvyānām*), 8.26.5b (*manyethām vṛṣaṇvasū*), 8.31.10c (*ắ víṣṇoḥ sacābhúvaḥ*), 8.69.8a (*árcata prắrcata*), 8.71.10b (*gíro yantu darśatám*), 8.98.4b (*satrājíd ágohyaḥ*), 9.18.7b (*punānó acikradat*), 9.113.5b (*sáṃ sravanti saṃsravắḥ*). Of the rest, five show – – ⏑ ⏒ ‖ and three show ⏑ ⏑ ⏑ ⏒ ‖, i.e. the two most frequent octosyllabic closing variations[4]); they are, respectively: 1.105.5a (*amí yé devā sthána*), 5.86.6a (*evéndrāgníbhyām*), 8.50.9a (*etávatas te vaso*), 8.74.4c (*yásya śrutárvā bṛhánn*), 8.74.8a (*sá te agne śaṃtamā*); and 5.7.10c (*ád agne ápṛṇato*), 8.84.1a (*préṣṭham vo átithim*), 9.98.8a (*asyá vo hy ávasā*).

We are led to conclude, then, that these verses, in the main, are actually neither catalectic, nor deviant, but *acephalic*.

Similarly, note that 17 of the 28 occurrences exhibit the two most common octosyllabic openings, again in the expected overall distribution; that is, ‖ (x) – – –, 10 times, and ‖ (x) – ⏑ –, 7 times[5]). Indeed, a careful analysis of the openings of both types is practically conclusive in itself. Consider the quantitative distribution of the first four syllables of 'catalectic' verses, tabulated in Figure 1:

	1	2	3	4
long	25	38	31	42
short	27	14	21	10

Figure 1: quantities of syllables 1–4, 'catalectic' verses

[3]) In the following discussion we ignore the seven-syllable verses in the important hymn 10.26, as well as those which occur in Trochaic Gāyatrī and in the so-called 'uneven lyric' hymns; these are discussed separately in section 2 below.

[4]) Arnold, op. cit., 159.

[5]) *Ibid.*, 150–1.

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Figure 1 clearly approximates to an overall pattern # ⏑ – ⏑ –, which accurately reflects the statistically preponderant forms of octosyllabic opening; these verses must therefore be analyzed as structurally catalectic.

The quantitative distribution of the first four syllables of 'heptasyllabic' verses, however, is quite different, as shown in Figure 2:

	1	2	3	4
long	21	19	21	11
short	7	9	7	17

Figure 2: quantities of syllables 1–4, 'heptasyllabic' verses

The scheme which emerges is # – ⏑ – ◡, a highly deviant structure for an octosyllabic opening; if we assume acephaly, however, the same syllables appear as

$$\# \; (\mathbf{x}) \; – \; ⏑ \; – \; \| \; \breve{} \; (– \; ◡ \; ⏑ \; \#)$$

which recovers, again, the most frequent octosyllabic opening pattern.

Thus the structures of both the opening and the closing of these verses confirm the theory that Arnold's 'heptasyllables' are to be analyzed as acephalic octosyllables. We are therefore provided with a straightforward structural distinction between the two seven-syllable types[6]).

2. *Distribution*

It is not our intention to present a full-scale analysis of the distribution of Vedic heptasyllables. It is desirable, however, to outline the larger metrical contexts in which seven-syllable verses occur.

An important distributional fact is that catalectic and acephalic verses co-occur in one and the same hymn approximately one-third of the time[7]). In order to examine this co-occurrence more care-

[6]) In the following discussion, we adopt the terminology 'catalectic' vs. 'acephalic'.

[7]) See Arnold's listings, 161; catalectic and acephalic verses co-occur in the following nine hymns: 1.132, 1.175, 5.7, 5.86, 8.25, 8.31, 8.46, 8.74, 10.26. Of these, only 1.132 is clearly non-archaic, on independent grounds; of the remainder, two are distinctly archaic (8.46, 10.26) and the rest may be; see Arnold's Metrical Tables, 269ff.

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fully, we consider briefly the best exemplar of this type, namely 10.26, which is found in the archaic Vimada collection[8]).

10.26 is both crucial and frustrating for the interpretation of Vedic heptasyllables. In this hymn we find the highest concentration of seven-syllable verses in any single hymn of the Rig-Veda; according to Arnold[9]), 'out of 36 verses 23 may be, and 11 must be, measured as catalectic or heptasyllabic; even the smaller figure is too large to be due to chance'. As Arnold's counts show, however, the metrical analysis of the hymn is hightly uncertain. It is important, nevertheless, to determine whether eight- and seven-syllable verses co-occur in this hymn in systematic fashion or in free alternation.

Nearly all of the syllabic indeterminacies are due to an extremely high concentration of genitive plurals in *-ām*. Arnold's intuition against disyllabic restoration to [-aam] in this hymn[10]), on the grounds that the shorter verse-length is 'more common', is not decisive[11]). Although the Vimada hymns[12]) are characterized by a strong unity of both metrical and linguistic design, comparison with metrical practice regarding genitive plurals in the other Vimada hymns is also inconclusive[13]). Finally, the overall syllabic design of the hymn is not significantly different whichever interpretation is assigned to the genitive plural forms. That is, the syllabic sequences which emerge (pāda-by-pāda and/or stanza-by-stanza) if we assume [-ām] throughout reveal no particular symmetry or other overriding principle of design, as compared with

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[8]) This hymn presents serious difficulties of interpretation; see the useful exegetical/bibliographical analysis in S. D. Atkins, *Pūṣan in the Rig-Veda* 87–90 (Princeton, 1941).

[9]) P. 161.

[10]) P. 89.

[11]) A complicating factor worth noticing is the rather striking parallelism of construction found in most of the verses with genitive plural, e.g. 2d *cíketa suṣṭutīnắm* cf. 3a *sá veda suṣṭutīnắm*; 4c *matīnắm ca sádhanam* cf. 4d *víprānām cādhavám*; 7a *inó vájānām pátir* cf. 7b *ináḥ puṣṭīnắm śakhā*. Intentional ambiguity is not excluded. (With regard to stanzas 1 and 4, the Anukramaṇī designation as Uṣṇih is clearly erroneous, and based on mere syllable-counting, as often).

[12]) 10.20–26, minus the late addition 10.24.4–6.

[13]) Out of ten genitive plurals in dimeter pādas, only three must be read as monosyllabic [-ām], 10.22.10d (2x) and 10.24.3c; particularly instructive are the consecutive verses 10.22.10cd (Bṛhatī stanza), with [-aam] in 10c: *gúhā yádī kavīnắm / viśắm nakṣatraśavasām*.

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the sequences which result if we assume [-aam] throughout. There is, then, no certainty in the interpretation of the genitive plurals in 10.26. Any patterns of stanzaic eight-/seven-syllable alternation are therefore effectively unrecoverable.

The distribution of pādas whose syllabic interpretation is unambiguous[14]) appears to be similarly unsystematic, with regard both to stanzaic organization and catalectic/acephalic alternation. There is every indication, then, that catalectic and acephalic verses co-occur among octosyllables as free variants.

As already seen by Arnold, seven-syllable verses are not uncommon in Trochaic Gāyatrī contexts[15]). But unlike 10.26 and similar hymns, seven-syllable verses in Trochaic Gāyatrī are almost exclusively catalectic[16]). It is difficult, however, to accept Arnold's view (161) that the frequency of seven-syllable verses in Trochaic Gāyatrī is 'due to the general irregularity of rhythm'. The rhythmic irregularities of Trochaic Gāyatrī are restricted to the opening[17]); most significant, however, is the fact that the highest number of seven-syllable verses occurs in 8.2 (9x) and 8.81 (4x), hymns composed entirely in Trochaic Gāyatrī (i.e. with more or less regular closing structures.) It is fairly clear that the frequency of attestation of catalectic verses in Trochaic Gāyatrī is directly proportional to the metrical consistency of the Trochaic Gāyatrī context; seven-syllable verses in scattered Trochaic Gāyatrī stanzas are rare. It is preferable, then, simply to regard Trochaic Gāyatrī as a verse-form which allows optional heptasyllables as a consistent feature.

The final metrical context in which heptasyllables figure prominently is the so-called 'uneven lyric' hymns[18]). These hymns are characterized by alternations of eight- and eleven-syllable verses within a single stanza. There are, however, numerous irregularities of meter and stanzaic structure which are found in most of the

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[14]) 1abc, 2a, 3b, 4b, 6d, 8ab, 9a.

[15]) P. 161 and the table at 153; see 52–3 and 165 for listings of stanzas and hymns composed in Trochaic Gāyatrī.

[16]) In addition to the standard catalectic closing ⏑ – ⏒ #, approximately one-third of the catalectic verses in Trochaic Gāyatrī show long fifth (and often sixth) syllable, as we might expect in contexts with trochaic closings. The openings of such verses confirm the classification as catalectic (vs. acephalic).

[17]) Arnold, 163.

[18]) *Ibid.*, 154 and 229–34.

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uneven lyric hymns. But amidst the irregularity, certain structural features are more or less clear[19]); most important are the following:

(1) the number of verses in the stanza is not fixed;

(2) there is rarely a regular succession of dimeter and trimeter verses;

(3) the dimeter verses are often, 'sometimes almost regularly', reduced to seven syllables.

Concerning factor (3) in particular, we note that Arnold analyzes the difficult hymns 1.88, 1.120.1–9[20]), and 10.105 as showing overall stanza-structures 11.11.7.11, 11.11.7, and 11.7.11, respectively[21]).

The seven-syllable verses of uneven lyric hymns present, again, many instances of syllabic indeterminacy; but their basic structure is clear: like the heptasyllables of Trochaic Gāyatrī, they are almost entirely of the catalectic type.

Rig-Vedic heptasyllables, then, are attested in the following metrical contexts:

TYPE A: Alternating 8/7 syllables, catalectic and acephalic (e.g. 10.26);

TYPE B: Alternating 8/7 syllables, catalectic (Trochaic Gāyatrī);

TYPE C: Alternating 11/7 syllables, catalectic (uneven lyric).

3. *Rig-Vedic heptasyllables and Indo-European verse*

In section 1 we sought to replace Arnold's vacuous distinction 'catalectic' vs. 'heptasyllabic' with the fairly clear-cut structural distinction of catalectic vs. acephalic. In terms of both general Indo-European and Indic metrics, it is important to note that no previous analysis has ever, to my knowledge, explained any facts of Vedic meter in terms of acephaly, whether as a synchronic or a diachronic process. Acephaly, however, is an important mechanism which is well-attested in other Indo-European metrical traditions, e.g. Greek and Irish.

We wish to suggest, however, that in addition to this purely 'mechanical' convergence, Greek and Irish furnish direct compa-

[19]) See Arnold, 229–30.

[20]) Verses 10–12 are late additions; see Arnold's Metrical Commentary ad loc.

[21]) Pp. 232–3.

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randa to the heptasyllabic metrical Types A, B and C outlined above.

There is general agreement that the Greek (octosyllabic) glyconic, iambic dimeter, and choriambic dimeter represent an underlying metrical structure cognate with the Vedic octosyllable[22]). The glyconic, ⏑⏑–⏑⏑–⏑⏑, has a heptasyllabic variant derived by catalexis, the pherecratean, ⏑⏑–⏑⏑–⏑[23]). In archaic Greek lyric verse, glyconics and pherecrateans freely alternate (occasionally also with choriambic dimeter[24]) in poems of the so-called 'polyschematist tradition'. Two well-known examples are Anacreon's hymn to Dionysus, and the extended fragment of Corinna[25]). In the latter, as often, the seven-syllable pherecratean functions as a clausula[26]). Although the same feature is apparent in the hymn of Anacreon, it is not obligatory; stanza one shows the structure *glyc.* + *glyc.* + *pher.* + *glyc.* + *chor. dim.*, vs. stanzas two and three, both with *glyc.* + *glyc.* + *pher.*

Another reflex of the same eight-/seven-syllable alternation is found in the so-called priapean, a (usually comic) dicolon whose first member may be a glyconic or a choriambic dimeter, and whose second member is either a pherecratean or an aristophanean (–⏑⏑–⏑–⏑)[27]). Watkins has observed[28]) that the underlying structure of the priapean (i.e., ⏑⏑⏑⏑⏑–⏑–⏑ plus ⏑⏑⏑⏑⏑–⏑) actually preserves a more archaic structure than the lyric glyconic/pherecratean alternation, since it shows the free initial and fixed closing reconstructable for Indo-European.

We propose, then, that the alternating eight-/seven-syllable Vedic types (A und B) are directly comparable to the Greek eight-/seven-syllable alternations attested in the glyconic/pherecratean

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[22]) Watkins, op. cit. (f. n. 1 above) passim; Nagy, op. cit., 27ff., 115ff., 140–1, 166ff.; for an account of the unitary origin of glyconic and iambic dimeter, see Watkins, 206, and for a discussion of the relation of choriambic dimeter to glyconic, see Watkins, 201ff. and Nagy, 43ff.

[23]) See e.g. B. Snell, *Griechische Metrik* 29 (Göttingen, 1957), A. M. Dale, *The lyric meters of Greek drama* 133 (Cambridge, 1968).

[24]) ⏑⏑⏑⏑–⏑⏑⏑ (with archaic free initial preserved), cf. the Trochaic Gāyatrī octosyllable ⏑⏑⏑⏑–⏑⏑–⏑.

[25]) D. L. Page, *Poetae Melici Graeci* ## 357 and 654, respectively (Oxford, 1962).

[26]) E.g. column iii, lines 17–21, with structure *chor. dim.* + *chor. dim.* + *glyc.* + *chor. dim.* + *pher.*; see also Watkins, 201.

[27]) See Dale, op. cit., 134.

[28]) Pp. 203–4.

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and the priapean: both traditions present verse-forms characterized by alternation of the Indo-European octosyllable with a variant derived by catalexis.

Thus far, we have not specifically accounted for the Vedic type (A) with acephalic variant. A Greek comparandum does, however, exist. The Greek analog to the Vedic acephalic verse is the telesillean, of the structure ⏑ – ◡ ◡ – ◡ ⏑, which must be analyzed as an acephalic glyconic[29]). In later contexts, it generally occurs paired with its own catalectic variant, the reizianum, though 'it is often found sporadically among the longer aeolics', as well as among glyconics[30]), e. g. Page # 892 (skolion), with *tel.* + *tel.* + *glyc.* + *glyc.*, or Sophocles, *OC.* 1044–9, with *tel* + *tel* + *tel* + *iamb. dim.* + *reiz.*

In one poem, however, the telesillean occurs in a metrical context which shows extremely archaic features, namely in the well-known Epidaurian Hymn to the Mother Goddess[31]). The bulk of this hymn is composed in telesilleans *κατὰ στίχον*, with occasional reizianum as clausula; lines 19–21, however, seem to show an irregular series:

19: *καὶ οὐκ ἄπειμι εἰς θεούς,* ◡ – ◡ – ◡ – ◡ ⏑
20: *ἂν μὴ τὰ μέρη λάβω,* – – ◡ ◡ – ◡ ⏑
21: *τὸ μὲν ἥμισυ οὐρανῶ* ◡ ◡ – ◡ ◡ – ◡ ⏑

Following Watkins' analysis of this passage[32]), line 19 is an iambic dimeter, line 20 another telesillean, and line 21 a glyconic[33]). The opening variations of lines 19 and 21 are not irregularities, but merely preserve the archaic free initial. This hymn, then, shows a verse-form of the structure (⏑) ⏑ ⏑ ⏑ ◡ – ◡ ⏑, comparable to the Vedic hymns in which octosyllables co-occur with acephalic variants.

Patterns strikingly similar to those discussed above can be found in Old Irish verse, where certain stanza-forms are derived both by acephaly and catalexis[34]). Without entering into a description of Irish versification, we note simply that the Irish *κατὰ στίχον* reflexes of the Indo-European short line (i.e. octosyllable) show an alternation of a 4–(or 5–) syllable type (= Indo-European octosyllable) and a 3–(or 4–) syllable type (= heptasyllable). Further, Watkins has shown that both catalexis and acephaly must be recognized

[29]) Snell, loc. cit.; Nagy, 283, 287–8.
[30]) Dale, 137–8. [31]) Page, # 935. [32]) Pp. 202–3.
[33]) Despite Page ad loc.: '*τὸ μὲν* pro ancipite'.
[34]) See Watkins, 227–34 and 234–5, respectively.

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as features of the Irish verse-forms which continue the inherited Indo-European short line[35]).

It is Old Irish, in fact, which presents the closest parallel to the Vedic type C (uneven lyric). Old Irish shows a non-strophic type in which the reflexes of the Indo-European long and short lines alternate, each with catalectic variants[36]); thus, example # 111, transposed into Indo-European syllabic terms, shows the structure 8.8.12.7.11.7.7. Here we see features directly comparable to the salient features of the Vedic uneven lyric type, where the synchronic asymmetrical syllabic alternations, stanza-to-stanza, may well point to an earlier non-strophic type such as that found in Old Irish (cf. the uneven lyric features (1) and (2) above)[37]).

In Greek, the standard Vedic lyric alternating eight- and twelve-syllable forms find cognates in such stanza-types as the well-known 'Archilochean dicolon', with alternating iambic trimeter and iambic dimeter, as has long been recognized. An analog to the uneven lyric type may perhaps have existed, judging from a quatrain of Alcman[38]) which shows the structure 11.11.11.7. The eleven-syllable lines in this stanza are to be analyzed descriptively as iambic trimeter catalectic, and diachronically as cognate with the Vedic Triṣṭubh[39]). The heptasyllabic fourth line shows a clear catalectic closing ⏑ – ⏑[40]).

We do not wish to claim that the Vedic, Greek and Irish verse-forms involving heptasyllables derive ultimately from unitary Indo-European sources, although this possibility is by no means excluded. We have, however, tried to demonstrate that the Vedic heptasyllabic verse-forms are derived (whether synchronically or diachronic-

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[35]) Cf. Watkins' example # 108, and the discussion at 245–6. (Watkins' observation that the structure of his example # 102 shows metrical relations identical to those among the Greek glyconic, pherecratean, telesillean and reizianum (p. 236) is not to be understood as a historical comparison, but only as a mechanical convergence, though not without interest; the verses of example # 102 continue the Indo-European long line of 11–12 syllables, not directly comparably to Greek glyconics etc.)

[36]) See Watkins, 240–1, with examples # 111 and # 112.

[37]) In addition, the trimeter verses of uneven lyric hymns not uncommonly appear as 12-syllable pādas.

[38]) Page, # 19.

[39]) This line is sporadically attested *κατὰ στίχον* also in Archilochus and Sappho; for references and analysis, see Nagy, 167 with footnotes 3 and 4.

[40]) The line-initial MS reading *πεδεστε* is certainly corrupt; a three-syllable reading here, however, is assured; see Page ad loc.

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ally) from mechanisms which are well-attested in the evolution of poetic structures elsewhere in Indo-European, namely catalexis and acephaly. Thus the heptasyllabic verses of the Rig-Veda, though statistically extremely rare, nonetheless pattern according to principles of metrical structure well-established for the complex of eleven- and twelve-syllable types in Vedic and elsewhere in Indo-European[41]). Far from being deviant, then, Vedic heptasyllables are important constituents in the framework of general Indo-European metrical practice.

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[41]) Cf. Nagy's analysis of the Sapphic hendecasyllable as an acephalic dodecasyllable, 302.

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